

Notes: Oberholzer-Gee & Waldfogel (AER, 2009)
**Media Markets and Localism: Does Local News en Español Boost Hispanic
Voter Turnout?**

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1 Big picture

- **Question.** Does access to local television news in Spanish increase Hispanic voter turnout and provide evidence that local media generates civic spillovers?
- **Setting.** U.S. metropolitan areas from 1994 to 2002, when Spanish-language local television news expanded unevenly across markets.
- **Main finding.** Spanish-language local television news raises Hispanic turnout by more than four percentage points, with stronger effects in nonpresidential elections and no effect on non-Hispanics.
- **Mechanism.** About one-quarter of Hispanics in markets with Spanish news watch it, largely substituting away from English local news.
- **Takeaway.** Local content can produce measurable civic spillovers for minority-language groups.

2 Incremental contribution

- Tests localism with voter turnout rather than abstract media-policy arguments.
- Uses expansion of Spanish-language local news as a rare identification window because English local news is nearly universal.
- Connects fixed-cost entry in differentiated media markets to political participation.
- Implements difference-in-differences and triple-difference logic comparing Hispanic vs. non-Hispanic turnout, news vs. no-news markets, and local vs. presidential election years.
- Adds mechanism evidence from actual viewing data.
- Distinguishes relevance of content from quantity of news consumption.

3 Data and measurement

The paper combines CPS Voting Supplement data, direct collection of Spanish-language local news availability from Telemundo and Univision stations, Scarborough TV-viewing data, and 1990/2000 Census demographics. The treatment is the presence or number of Spanish-language local television news stations in a metro area. The main outcome is individual voter turnout. Mechanism outcomes are local news viewing in Spanish and English.

4 Models and empirical specifications

4.1 News entry

$$NewsEntry_m = a + b_1 \log(HispanicPop_m) + b_2 \log(NonHispanicPop_m) + X_m\gamma + u_m.$$

Detailed interpretation: Entry should be tied to Hispanic population size if fixed costs and audience size drive Spanish-language local news supply.

4.2 Main turnout equation

$$V_{imt} = \alpha HLN_{mt} + \alpha_H Hispanic_i \times HLN_{mt} + X_{it}\beta + Hispanic_i \times X_{it}\beta_H + \phi_t + Hispanic_i \times \phi_t^H + \mu_m + \varepsilon_{imt}.$$

Detailed interpretation: The coefficient of interest is α_H , the differential effect of Spanish local news on Hispanic turnout relative to non-Hispanic turnout.

4.3 Mechanism regression

Scarborough ordered probits relate self-reported local election participation to hours watching local news in Spanish and English.

5 Identification and empirical design

The central challenge is that Spanish-language news is not randomly assigned. The paper addresses this using metro fixed effects, group-specific controls, Hispanic population controls, a presidential-year triple difference, and mechanism evidence from viewing data. The key falsification logic is that Spanish local news should not affect non-Hispanic turnout and should matter less in presidential years when national media dominate.

6 Section-by-section study guide

- **Introduction:** motivates localism and civic spillovers.
- **Data:** explains CPS, station collection, Scarborough, and Census data.
- **Entry:** shows Spanish news entry depends on Hispanic population size.
- **Turnout:** estimates the difference-in-differences/triple-difference turnout model.
- **Mechanism:** shows Hispanics substitute toward Spanish local news and that Spanish-news viewing predicts local election participation.
- **Conclusion:** links local content to civic engagement.

7 Tables and figures

7.1 Table 1: growth in Spanish local news and Table 2: entry regressions

Read: Table 1 documents growth in Spanish-language local news; Table 2 shows that entry is predicted by Hispanic population size.

Detailed interpretation: Entry is consistent with fixed costs and audience size rather than general market size or observable political-interest characteristics.

Economic message: Minority-language local content appears where the group is large enough to support production.

TABLE 3—VOTER TURNOUT AND THE PRESENCE OF SPANISH-LANGUAGE LOCAL TELEVISION NEWS

	Turnout (1)	Turnout (2)	Turnout (3)	Turnout (4)	Turnout (5)
Hispanic	−0.227 (0.012)**	−0.225 (0.015)**	−0.103 (0.020)**	−0.117 (0.015)**	−0.107 (0.020)**
Spanish local news presence	−0.001 (0.007)	−0.004 (0.007)	−0.006 (0.007)	−0.014 (0.007)	0.005 (0.010)
Hispanic × Spanish local news	0.082 (0.011)**	0.076 (0.015)**	0.051 (0.016)**	0.083 (0.010)**	0.047 (0.017)**
Hispanic × Spanish local news × presidential year	−0.035 (0.018)*	−0.041 (0.018)*	−0.037 (0.019)*	−0.027 (0.011)*	−0.038 (0.019)*
log Hispanic population		0.053 (0.008)**	0.060 (0.009)**		0.034 (0.009)**
Hispanic × log Hispanic population		0.002 (0.004)	0.013 (0.004)**		0.015 (0.004)**
Group-specific personal controls?	No	No	Yes	Yes	Yes
MSA FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Additional controls?	No	No	No	Hispanic population in 1990 × year FE	State FE for states with new stations × year FE
Observations	240,740	230,151	230,151	231,361	230,151

Table 3: voter turnout and Spanish local news

TABLE 1—GROWTH IN METRO AREAS WITH SPANISH-LANGUAGE LOCAL TELEVISION

	None	One station	Two stations
1994	269	11	5
1996	267	12	5
1998	264	14	6
2000	261	14	9
2002	257	16	10

Note: In our sample period, local news in Spanish was introduced in markets located in CO, FL, MD, NV, TX, UT, VA, and WV.

gesting it is the relevancy of information that increases participation. In the case of Spanish-language news, the spillovers from local media do not appear to be fairly important, and they contribute to the policy discussion.

(a) Table 1: growth in Spanish local news

TABLE 2—ENTRY OF SPANISH-LANGUAGE LOCAL TELEVISION NEWS (1994–2002)

	News entry (indicator) (1)	News entry (indicator) (2)	News entry (number of stations) (3)
log of Hispanic population	0.0123 (0.0060)**	0.00419 (0.0044)*	0.0383 (0.010)**
log of non-Hispanic population	0.00174 (0.0031)	0.000704 (0.0023)	0.0185 (0.017)
Median Hispanic income (000)		0.000614 (0.00067)	0.00278 (0.0029)
Hispanic share completed college		−0.0894 (0.082)	−0.166 (0.20)
Hispanic share over 40		−0.000504 (0.061)	0.0336 (0.28)
Hispanic share female		0.125 (0.16)	0.367 (0.40)
Constant			−0.00209 (0.22)
Observations	280	280	280
R ²			0.14

Notes: In columns 1 and 2, the dependent variable is 1 if the market received at least one additional Spanish-language local news show during our study period. We report probability derivatives. In column 3, which gives regression coefficients, the dependent variable is the number of new shows. Standard errors are in parentheses.

** Significant at the 1 percent level.

* Significant at the 5 percent level.

(b) Table 2: entry regressions

7.2 Table 3: voter turnout and Spanish local news

Read: The Hispanic times Spanish local news coefficient is positive and significant across specifications; the presidential-year interaction is negative.

Detailed interpretation: Spanish local news raises Hispanic local-election turnout and the pattern is consistent with a local-information mechanism.

Economic message: Relevant local media content increases civic participation.

7.3 Table 4: local-news consumption and Table 5: political participation

Read: Table 4 shows Hispanics substitute from English local news to Spanish local news; Table 5 shows Spanish local-news viewing predicts local election participation.

Detailed interpretation: The mechanism is relevance and accessibility, not simply more total news consumption.

Economic message: Spanish-language local content lowers the cost of obtaining politically useful information.

TABLE 4—PATTERNS OF LOCAL NEWS CONSUMPTION

Respondents	Markets	News	Percent watching local news	Number of segments watched	Percent segments watched
Non-Hispanics	Without news in Spanish		65.9 (47.4)	4.1 (5.0)	27.3 (31.3)
		With news in Spanish	63.6 (48.1)	3.8 (4.7)	21.9 (27.0)
	News in English	News in Spanish	0.4 (6.0)	0.0 (0.2)	0.3 (4.7)
		Any news	63.9 (48.0)	3.9 (4.9)	18.6 (22.9)
			61.8 (48.6)	3.7 (4.8)	24.1 (29.3)
Hispanics	Without news in Spanish		41.2 (49.2)	2.1 (3.6)	12.5 (21.9)
		With news in Spanish	25.6 (43.6)	0.9 (2.0)	25.5 (36.1)
	News in English	News in Spanish	63.5 (48.1)	3.1 (3.8)	14.7 (17.8)
		Any news	+1.7	−0.6	−9.4
Δ for Hispanics across markets with and without local news in Spanish			0.05	0.00	0.00
H_0 : Δ for Hispanics = 0 (Prob > z)					

Notes: The variable “percent watching local news” is the fraction of persons who report they watch a local news program during a one-week period. “Number of segments” is the mean number of half-hour local news segments that respondents watch. “Percent segments” is the ratio of the mean number of half-hours of local news that respondents watch to the number of half-hours that are available in a market. Standard deviations are in parentheses. The last row reports Mann-Whitney U tests comparing the behavior of Hispanic respondents across markets with and without local news in Spanish.

Source: Scarborough data, based on 178,784 respondents.

TABLE 5—LOCAL NEWS IN SPANISH AND HISPANIC POLITICAL PARTICIPATION

	Local elections (1)	Local elections (2)	Local elections (3)	National elections (4)
Market with local news in Spanish (indicator)	−0.023 (0.081)	−0.024 (0.081)	−0.021 (0.083)	−0.003 (0.081)
Hours watched local news in Spanish		0.061 (0.028)*	0.072 (0.029)*	−0.011 (0.019)
Hours watched local news in English			0.020 (0.004)**	
Demographic controls?	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Observations	25,534	25,534	25,534	25,534

Notes: The coefficients are ordered probits, estimated on a sample of Hispanics who are registered to vote. We employ the sample weights provided by Scarborough. We report robust standard errors, clustered on 66 local media markets, in parentheses. The dependent variable is the response to the question, “How often do you vote in local (national) elections?” There are three outcomes: 1 = never, 2 = sometimes, 3 = always. All models include controls for income (15 indicators) and gender.

*Significant at the 1 percent level.

**Significant at the 5 percent level.

(a) Table 4: local-news consumption

(b) Table 5: political participation

8 Result map

- Entry: Spanish local news appears where Hispanic population is large enough.
- Turnout: Hispanic turnout rises in markets with Spanish news; non-Hispanic turnout does not.
- Election type: effect is smaller in presidential years.
- Mechanism: Hispanics watch Spanish news where available and substitute away from English news.
- Policy: localism can generate civic spillovers.

9 Short summary

Spanish-language local TV news increased Hispanic local-election turnout by making local political information more accessible and relevant. The evidence combines entry patterns, CPS turnout regressions, and Scarborough viewing data.

10 Conclusion

10.1 Core conclusion

Spanish-language local television news increases Hispanic political participation in local elections.

10.2 Economic intuition

Local political participation depends on access to relevant local information. Spanish-language news lowers that information cost for many Hispanics.

10.3 Incremental contribution

The paper uses minority-language local news entry to identify civic spillovers from local media, linking media market entry to political economy outcomes.

10.4 Takeaway

Local media matters when it reaches groups otherwise underserved by integrated national media markets.